



Historic feat: India beat Germany 5-4 in Tokyo to win an Olympic medal in men's hockey after 41 years.

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are trying to create. You can be honest in that space and drive standards and performance levels. It then becomes easier to communicate, regardless of the language.

In one of Sportstar's in-house discussions with India captain Harmanpreet Singh, former India skipper V. Baskaran had said that captains should have a say in selection matters. Your thoughts?

No. The captain doesn't have much say. It's not like cricket. It is different. But at the same time, all the leaders' opinions are important. It is not fair to place the final selection on the captain. The coaching staff will do that. The captain will then lead the leadership group and implement the plans.

Describe your dynamic with players: Are you more of a strict disciplinarian or a laid-back individual?

We have a good balance. They work hard and play. It is a good, honest

group. At the same time, there is time for fun and time to be serious. They are enjoying it. They also want to get better.

What do you do to deal with the demanding nature of the sport?

I've been in a team environment for a long time. As an individual pursuit, I play golf as a hobby, as it helps me switch off. It takes me away [from the pressure] for a longer time.

You and your wife, Natalie, have played hockey for South Africa. In the 2004 Olympics, you two became the first married couple to represent South Africa at the same Olympic Games. How is it to have a wife who is a hockey player?

Nats (Natalie) is a very competitive player in her own right. It's nice to have her opinion. She tells us when we play well and when we don't play well.

That's great. I would not have been able to do what I am doing without Nats because she has to look after the house and the children. There's a lot that goes into it. I am away from home a lot. That's an agreement we have made for the period. It's not going to last forever. It is good to have a partner who

knows the sport. She realises what goes into work.

What are your thoughts on teams losing badly to top teams at the Senior National Championships in Chennai? Does the format need a tweak?

We can do with a better format. Now, it's a little bit frustrating for weaker teams to play and lose badly to the top teams. The talent is good. I think some teams are more prepared than others.

That's the discrepancy. If we split them and get strength on strength, it will be a different competition. We are discussing it, and if the coaches agree with it, I think we can set it up.

The core group of the Indian men's team is already formed. How much of the existing talent can be part of the core group?

The exciting talent here can be considered. There are a handful of good talents who can go for the selection trials. That would be a realistic way of doing it. Of course, there will be no change in the core group.

What do you like about the new talent you saw in Chennai?